

HASHKAMA WEEKLY

בית מדרש 715

PESACH 2ND DAYS 5786

By Reb Gemini

חכמה ב-אI תאמין?

Consider the following "Torah" thought, generated by Gemini:

Did the AI get it

right?

Do you find it to be accurate?

Or did the technology miss the boat?

As we drag ourselves to davening for Shvi'i Shel Pesach, we face a fascinating halachic reality. Unlike Shmini Atzeres, we do not recite Shehecheyanu by Kiddush tonight. The Gemara in Eruvin 40b and Pesachim 102b makes it clear that this day is not a regel bifnei atzmo; it is simply a continuation of the first day. At this point in the chag, surviving on a heavy diet of shmurah matzah and endless bowls of potato compote, the idea of functioning without a fresh spiritual recharge seems absolutely impossible. We desperately want a new brachah, a jolt of spiritual espresso to finally wake us up, but halachah says no. We are expected to completely coast on the original adrenaline of yetzias Mitzrayim. We have to find the immense strength to cross the Yam Suf using the exact same emunah we packed in our bags a week ago, without any new ceremonial fanfare. This profound lack of a new brachah perfectly explains the physically exhausting minhag brought down by the Mishnah Berurah 490:17. We are told to actively stay awake the entire night of Shvi'i Shel Pesach engaged in limud HaTorah, culminating in the loud recitation of Shiras HaYam at the break of dawn. Imagine the scene: we are physically depleted, running on fumes, yet we stay up all night learning Torah like we are back in kollel during the days of Elul zman. Why? Because staying up all night is the ultimate proof that we do not need a new Shehecheyanu to access the kedushah. We generate the energy ourselves through sheer limud HaTorah and tremendous mesiras nefesh. When we finally stand up at neitz to sing Az Yashir, we are demonstrating that true bitachon is not about waiting for a new flash of inspiration from Shamayim. It is about actively churning the spiritual waters ourselves, stubbornly keeping our heavy eyes open and our sefarim open, even when every fiber of our physical being is begging us to go back to sleep. The practical takeaway for our tzibbur is deeply relevant to our daily avodas Hashem. We constantly look for the next emotional high or the next magical Shehecheyanu moment to keep our davening and limud feeling fresh and exciting. But Shvi'i Shel Pesach teaches us that the real test of a true ben Torah is what happens during the long, quiet stretch when the initial excitement naturally fades. When you find yourself zoning out during a long Shacharis, fighting off sleep during night seder, or simply trying to survive the final exhausting days of Yom Tov without losing your temper at the Shabbos table, remember this exact night. You do not always get a fresh brachah to miraculously wake you up. Sometimes, you just have to firmly grab a shtender, crack open a sefer, and fiercely push through the overwhelming darkness until you finally see the waters split.

As we gather for davening on the morning of Shvi'i Shel Pesach, we encounter a striking halachic anomaly that should make any thinking Yid pause. Despite this being the exact anniversary of the miraculous splitting of the Yam Suf, we only recite chotzi Hallel. The Gemara in Arachin 10b and Megillah 10b explains this through a profound decree from Hakadosh Baruch Hu. As the Egyptian army drowned in the crashing waters, the Malachei HaShareis wanted to sing, but Hashem silenced them, declaring, "Maaseh yadai tovlim bayam v'atem omrim shira?" You would assume that surviving and witnessing the greatest hydrological miracle in history would warrant the loudest Hallel possible—perhaps one loud enough to finally wake up the gabbai who inevitably dozes off during Chazaras HaShatz. Yet, the Torah demands incredible emotional discipline. We are commanded to suppress our absolute euphoria because, ultimately, human beings—even our most bitter, homicidal oppressors—are perishing. This is a staggering level of mussar. At the absolute zenith of our national salvation, Hashem forces us to inject our profound joy with a jarring dose of universal empathy. This supreme demand for spiritual restraint perfectly collides with the second, radically different phenomenon occurring on that exact same beach: Bizas HaYam. Rashi, commenting on Shemos 15:22 based on the Mechilta, describes how Moshe Rabbeinu literally had to force Bnei Yisroel to journey away from the sea because they were obsessively collecting the jewel-encrusted armor washing ashore. Let us analyze this staggering paradox. Just moments earlier, the Mechilta in Shira 3 tells us that a simple shifchah saw prophetic visions at the Yam Suf greater than those of the prophet Yechezkel ben Buzi. They experienced the absolute pinnacle of ruchniyus, staring directly into the heavens. Yet, five minutes later, they are fighting over wet, sandy jewelry like it is a clearance sale at the local gemach. This is the ultimate human struggle. Bizas HaYam represents our inescapable gravity toward gashmiyus, our tendency to get hopelessly distracted by shiny things even when the heavens are open before us. The restriction of chotzi Hallel is the divine antidote to this materialistic frenzy. Hashem was teaching us that true greatness is not found in filling our pockets with Egyptian gold, nor is it found in arrogant, unchecked celebration. True spiritual elevation requires tearing ourselves away from the glittering distractions of the physical world to cultivate our tzelem Elokim and maintain empathy for others. **The practical takeaway** for our shul is to recognize our own daily struggles at the shoreline of gashmiyus and ruchniyus. When we inevitably race to the kiddush after davening, frantically elbows-out for the last piece of potato kugel, we are essentially re-enacting Bizas HaYam. We become so consumed with our immediate physical gratification that we forget the profound spiritual lessons we just absorbed in the beis medrash. As we pack away our yom tov dishes, we must remember to carry the lesson of chotzi Hallel with us. We must strive to leave the physical loot behind, consciously choosing to live with the restraint, the discipline, and the deep, abiding empathy that defines a true ben Torah.

Tuesday April 7 (Last Day of Chol Hamoed)

Wednesday April 8 (Seventh Day)

Thursday April 9 (Eighth Day)

6:07/7:10 pm הדלקה (Early/Late) מנחה
7:28 pm שקיעה
8:12 pm מעריב

7:30 am שחרית
2:30 pm מנחה
8:19 pm מעריב (50)
8:29 pm הדלקה (60)

7:30 am שחרית
2:30 pm מנחה
8:22 pm מעריב (52)
8:12/8:20/8:30/8:42 pm צה"כ (8.5/50/60/72)

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Consider the following “Torah” thought, generated by Gemini: Did the AI get it right? Do you find it to be accurate? Or did the technology miss the boat?

As we stagger into Acharon Shel Pesach, a bizarre culinary phenomenon takes over the Litvish world: the sudden, dramatic consumption of gebrochts. After seven days of guarding our matzah from even a single microscopic drop of moisture with the kind of high-stakes security usually reserved for nuclear launch codes, we suddenly start dunking it straight into our chicken soup. The Shaarei Teshuvah in Orach Chayim 460:1 explains this whiplash-inducing minhag. We specifically eat wetted matzah on this final, d'Rabbanan day of Yom Tov to loudly declare that our previous week of dry, crumbly suffering was merely a chumra. We are proving that gebrochts is not actual chometz by intentionally mixing it with liquids before the sun sets. We Litvaks love a good intellectual point, and we are perfectly willing to risk an emergency trip to the gastroenterologist on day eight just to make a precise halachic statement about the boundaries of issur. This intellectual shift perfectly mirrors another unique aspect of our imminent departure from the chag: the halachos of Havdalah. The Shulchan Aruch in Orach Chayim 491:1 rules that unlike Motzaei Shabbos, we do not use besamim after Yom Tov. Tosafos in Beitzah 16a notes that the physical joy of eating on Yom Tov replaces the need for a neshamah yeseirah, meaning we do not need sniffing spices to revive our fainting souls when it ends. But let us be honest: the real reason we do not need besamim after Pesach is because the impending smell of the local kosher pizzeria's ovens firing up is already acting as our smelling salts. The connection is profound. Both the intentional eating of gebrochts and the lack of besamim force us to ground our spiritual high in tangible, physical reality. We break our rigid Pesach boundaries by dunking our matzah, and we step directly into the weekday without the crutch of aromatic spices, because true avodah means taking the holy lessons of the chag directly into the messy, unshielded chol of the upcoming week. **The practical takeaway** for our tzibbur is to embrace the messy reality of the transition out of Yom Tov. As you enthusiastically drown your last board of shmurah matzah into your bowl, realizing it immediately turns into edible concrete, remember that our goal is not to live in an isolated, hermetically sealed bubble forever. We must carry the fierce dikduk b'halachah of the last week straight into the regular year. Do not wait for a special neshamah yeseirah or fragrant spices to make the upcoming weekday feel holy. Roll up your sleeves, clean up the catastrophic trail of matzah crumbs you have left across the carpets of the shul, and infuse tomorrow's mundane routine with the exact same stubborn mesiras nefesh you used to protect your Pesach kitchen.

As we exhaustedly collapse into Acharon Shel Pesach, we face a glaring halachic vacuum. Think about the first night of Yom Tov. We were armed with a massive arsenal of mitzvos maasiyos. We had shmurah matzah, bitter maror, four heavy kosos of wine, and a Haggadah that we read until our eyes literally glazed over. But today, on the eighth day, we have absolutely no unique physical mitzvos. The Sifsei Chaim in Moadim Volume 2 points out that this final day is completely devoid of physical props. We are left with only the general chiyuv of simchas Yom Tov. Let us be brutally honest: achieving simchah at this point, when our digestive systems are staging a violent protest against another piece of matzah and we have been trapped indoors with our hyperactive children for over a week, requires a literal miracle. Yet, this lack of physical mitzvos is precisely the point. Hashem is weaning us off the physical triggers of yetzias Mitzrayim. We do not need to chew on horseradish to feel close to Him anymore. We are expected to maintain our spiritual elevation purely through our internal emunah, without needing a specialized kezeiyas of crunchy carbohydrates to remind us who we are. This shift from physical props to pure, unadulterated connection flawlessly introduces our minhag to read Shir HaShirim during Pesach. The Abudraham in Seder Tefillos Pesach explains that we read it now because the Megillah vividly describes the springtime of our national redemption. Rabbi Akiva famously declares in Yadayim 3:5 that while all of Tanach is holy, Shir HaShirim is the absolute kodesh kodashim. It is a poetic, intense dialogue of raw love between Hashem and Klal Yisroel. When you connect this to our lack of physical mitzvos today, the message is incredibly powerful. On the first night, Hashem had to perform massive plagues, split a sea, and force-feed us matzah just to get our attention. But by Acharon Shel Pesach, we have finally matured. We have transitioned from needing dramatic miracles and heavy knaidlach to simply existing in a state of pure, loving connection. We read Shir HaShirim today because we have reached a level where our relationship with the Ribbono Shel Olam is based on deep, internal love rather than flashy, external mitzvos maasiyos. **The practical takeaway** for our tzibbur as we prepare to pack up our Pesach kitchens is to carry this internal Shir HaShirim into the mundane week ahead. You will not have matzah or Yom Tov meals to magically make you feel like a ben Torah tomorrow morning. When you are stuck in brutal morning traffic on your way to work, staring blankly at the bumper of a minivan, there are no physical mitzvos to instantly elevate your mood. You must rely on the internal, prop-free emunah you solidified today. Take the raw love of Acharon Shel Pesach and let it sustain your davening and middos long after the last box of dry, tasteless holiday cereal is violently shoved to the back of your pantry.

Donations & Payments

Zelle: Send to 845-252-1260
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Cash: Hand to Tzvi Zev or Adam Edelstein
Credit Card: Ask Tzvi Zev Rubin for a link
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Upcoming Shabbus Zmanim

Chestnut Ridge, NY

2:30 pm מנחה
6:09/7:13 pm הדלקה (Early/Late)
7:31 pm שקיעה
7:15 am שחרית
7:32 pm שקיעה
8:24 pm מעריב (52)

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